STELLA (YAXUAN) MAO

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SUMMARY

UX Researcher running end-to-end **mixed-methods** studies for **AI**, **enterprise** and **assistive** products: **usability testing**, **controlled experiments**, **surveys**, **interviews** and **co-design**. Turns findings into prioritized, owner-mapped product decisions. 9 first-/co-authored papers, including CSCW, RO-MAN and IEEE VR.

EDUCATION

University of Washington, Seattle — M.S. Human Centered Design & Engineering, GPA 4.0/4.0 *Sep 2025 – Jun 2027 (Expected)*

City University of Hong Kong — B.S. Creative Media, Magna Cum Laude (top 7% of cohort) *Sep 2020 – Jun 2024*

EXPERIENCE

Digital China, Beijing — UX Researcher Intern *Apr 2025 – Aug 2025*

- Raised enterprise HR LLM agent response accuracy from **32% to 86% (+54 pp)** by leading **human-in-the-loop evaluation** and **user-intent analysis** with engineers to refine the prompting strategy
- Identified key usability bottlenecks in generated responses and delivered actionable product recommendations

University of Washington, Seattle — Research Assistant (UX Research) *Sep 2025 – Present*

- Ran a community-based **field study** with adults with severe motor limitations using a teleoperated robot across 4 input methods (switch, head-dwell, touch, AAC), combining observation, interviews and rating scales
- Designed **semi-structured interview** protocols and led **thematic analysis** for a digital mental-health intervention for adolescents
- Iterated an educational robot prototype through **K-12 co-design workshops** with students and teachers; built interaction logging

Tsinghua University, Beijing — Research Assistant (UX Research) *Apr 2025 – Oct 2025*

- Increased **reading engagement 26.7%** and **participation 15.9%** in user testing by designing a companion robot from interview, thematic-coding and usability-metric insights; extended an open-source prototype with custom Arduino features (RO-MAN 2026)

BiWell Lab, City University of Hong Kong — Research Assistant (UX Research) *Jun 2023 – Mar 2025*

- Defined product requirements for a pediatric VR intervention by leading **co-design workshops** with 13 children and interviewing 13 parents and 2 dentists (CSCW 2025, first author)
- Built and validated an Unreal Engine prototype from these requirements, improving children's comfort and engagement

SELECTED UX RESEARCH PROJECTS

SAGE Usability Study, sponsored by UW Office of Research — Student Project, team of 4 *Jan 2026 – Feb 2026*

- Showed that **4 of 5 expert users made critical errors despite 100% task success** (SUS 52 vs. 68 benchmark) through **heuristic evaluation** and 5 **moderated think-aloud** sessions; the product team added the prioritized, owner-mapped fixes to its backlog

AI Workflow and Automation Bias Experiment — First author, under review at CHI *Sep 2025 – Aug 2026*

- Found that showing AI advice first raised acceptance of wrong AI flags by **67% at equal accuracy**, through a randomized online **experiment (N=100)** with behavioral logs and **mixed-effects models in R**

ADDITIONAL EXPERIENCE

SeeWall Limited, Hong Kong — Co-Founder & Product Director *Aug 2021 – Feb 2023*

- Shipped an audio-navigation app and a wearable obstacle-avoidance belt for visually impaired users that **improved navigation accuracy 28%** and **reduced user hesitation 35%**, after leading 50+ interviews and usability tests; won HK$100,000 seed funding (HK Tech 300)

SKILLS & AWARDS

Research: usability testing, heuristic evaluation, semi-structured interviews, surveys, co-design workshops, A/B and controlled experiments, SUS, thematic analysis, affinity mapping, personas

Analysis & tools: R (mixed-effects models), Python, SQL, Qualtrics, Prolific, Figma, Miro · **Prototyping:** JavaScript, HTML/CSS, Arduino, Unreal Engine 5

Awards: Seed Fund Award, HK Tech 300 (HK$100,000) · Hong Kong Government Scholarship Nomination